UP: ARE MUSLIMS ANGRY WITH AKHILESH? PG 9

MP: MAOISTS FIND SANCTUARY IN KANHA PG 14

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BIHAR:NITISH SHOWS WHO'S THE BOSS PG 16



Illustration by NILANJAN DAS

ELECTRIC VEHICLES

TRIAL BY FIRE

By M.G.Arun

On April 22, Kotakonda Siva Kumar, 40, a graphic designer based in Vijayawada in Andhra Pradesh, bought a new e-scooter for Rs 70,000. He plugged in the scooter's battery to charge overnight, but, while the vehicle was still charging, it caught fire and exploded, killing Kumar. His wife and two daughters sustained severe burn injuries. The incident came days after a container with 20 electric scooters caught fire while being transported in Nashik in Maharashtra on April 12. In March, Durai Verma, 49, and his daughter had choked to death in Vellore in Tamil Nadu, after their new e-bike, kept to charge overnight, caught fire. Half a dozen incidents of electric bikes catching fire in India have been reported in less than a month. A concerned central government has launched a probe into the incidents and warned manufacturers of the e-bikes in question of hefty penalties if they are found to be at fault. "If any company is found negligent in their processes, a heavy penalty will be imposed and a recall of all defective vehicles will also be ordered," said Nitin Gadkari, the Union minister for road